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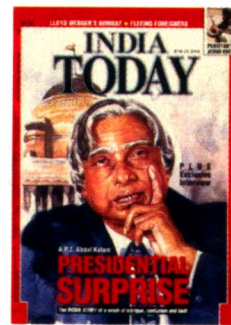
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Ever since June 25, 1975, when President Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed signed the proclamation of the Emergency, the office of the President of India has assumed a new significance. Earlier, the powers vested by the Constitution normally lay dormant and the post was purely ceremonial. In today's coalition era, both in the Centre and the state, and the rise of divisive politics, these powers can play a critical role in our politics. No wonder the recent 2007 presidential election was somewhat of a mudslinging match. India now has a new President and another, with a remarkable term of office, is leaving.

Outgoing President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, when appointed, was a rank outsider in politics, widely expected to be at a loss in the chaos of coalition politics. But he has left a distinctive mark on the presidency. His predecessors were men of formidable stature but the office of President had a certain aloofness. Kalam turned out to be a people's President who opened the doors of the Rashtrapati Bhavan to children, farmers, policemen and the common man. Several million people visited Raisina Hill during his tenure. Besides that, he was a superb communicator. He realised that he could use his office to talk about issues outside politics that were important to India. Above all, he believed in India. He spoke in great depth and detail about how India could become a world power and be economically developed by the year 2020.



Our June 2002 cover

I met him on several occasions and his most outstanding characteristic was his child-like curiosity, enthusiasm, charm and innocence. When he addressed the INDIA TODAY Conclave in 2003, Kalam was the only one who read the speeches made by all the speakers before him. He then made one of his famous laptop presentations. The only President to ever do so.

Our cover story this week is about the Kalam presidency and has been put together by Managing Editor Raj Chengappa who has known Kalam the scientist for 25 years. Chengappa interviewed Kalam exclusively just before he entered Rashtrapati Bhavan in 2002. In his last interview as President, Kalam spoke to Chengappa again. Chengappa says of Kalam, "Even at 75, you can sense a can-do spirit in the man."

We conducted a subjective in-house poll amongst our senior political staff to rank India's presidents on five counts including independence, constitutional propriety and relationship with the government. India's first three presidents occupied the first three spots, but Kalam was not far behind at No. 4. The highest among modern presidents.

Avul Pakir Jainulabdeen Abdul Kalam made the presidency his own. His will be a hard act to follow. Good luck, Madam President.

Aaron Purie
(Aron Purie)